

CONFINED SPACE TOOLBOX TALK

Control atmospheric hazards, energy sources and rescue risks.

8-10 MINUTES

OBJECTIVE

Review oxygen deficiency or enrichment, toxic and flammable atmospheres, unexpected energy, engulfment, entrapment and delayed-rescue hazards, and verify that the permit, gas testing, isolation, ventilation, attendant and rescue arrangements are complete before entry.

TOPIC EXPLANATION

- A confined space includes tanks, columns, reactors, ducts, pits, manholes, silos and similar areas with limited entry or exit, not designed for continuous occupancy and capable of containing atmospheric or physical hazards.
- Before entry, the atmosphere must be tested at upper, middle and lower levels with a suitable gas detector. Oxygen, flammable gas and expected toxic gases must be checked, and continuous monitoring must be used where conditions may change.
- The attendant must remain outside, maintain communication and avoid unrelated duties. The attendant must not enter for an unplanned rescue. The rescue plan, team, tripod, winch or other equipment must be ready and practical before entry begins.

REALISTIC SITE SCENARIO

- A worker entered a tank for a short inspection. The entry permit was incomplete and the most recent gas test had been completed several hours earlier.
- Residual process material reduced the oxygen level. The worker lost consciousness, and a second worker entered without protection in an attempt to rescue the casualty.
- The event could have been prevented through current gas testing, continuous monitoring, a dedicated attendant, controlled entry and a non-entry rescue arrangement.

REMEMBER

Entering a confined space without a rescue plan can create a second casualty. Raise the alarm and follow the approved rescue procedure.

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Hazards, entry controls and daily pre-work verification.

8-10 MINUTES

KEY HAZARDS

- Oxygen deficiency or oxygen enrichment.
- Fire or explosion from flammable gases, vapours or dust.
- H₂S, CO, solvent vapours or other toxic substances.
- Unexpected flow, pressure, steam or product entry.
- Moving equipment and inadequate energy isolation.
- Engulfment in liquid, powder or loose material.
- Restricted access, falls, slips and entrapment.
- Heat stress, poor visibility and communication failure.

CONTROL MEASURES

- Verify the approved confined-space entry permit.
- Isolate the space and all connected energy sources.
- Test the atmosphere at upper, middle and lower levels.
- Provide continuous atmospheric monitoring where required.
- Provide adequate mechanical ventilation.
- Assign a competent and dedicated attendant.
- Maintain continuous communication with entrants.
- Record entry, exit and personnel count.
- Prepare the rescue plan, team and equipment before entry.
- Evacuate immediately if conditions change.

SUPERVISOR TALKING SCRIPT

Team, no one will enter today until the permit, isolation and current gas testing are complete. Atmospheric conditions will be monitored throughout the work where required. The attendant will remain outside, avoid unrelated duties and track everyone entering and leaving. During an alarm, no one will enter for an unplanned rescue; the approved rescue plan will be followed.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- Is the confined-space entry permit approved and current?
- Who completed the latest gas test and what were the results?
- Which energy and process connections have been isolated?
- Who is the attendant and how will communication be maintained?
- How will continuous gas monitoring be provided?
- Where are the rescue team and equipment positioned?

VERIFY BEFORE STARTING TODAY

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Entry permit approved | ☐ Risk assessment suitable |
| ☐ Isolation complete | ☐ Gas test acceptable |
| ☐ Detector checked | ☐ Ventilation ready |
| ☐ Attendant in position | ☐ Communication established |
| ☐ Rescue equipment ready | ☐ Entry log started |

ATTENDANCE AND APPROVAL

CONFINED SPACE TOOLBOX TALK

Project / Site

Date

Presented by

Work area

No	Full Name	Company / Role	Signature
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			

Supervisor notes / additional site instructions